

THE UNSHAKEN SELF

Key Lessons from the Gita for a Life Without Doubt, Worry, and Fear

CHAPTER 1 — FREE SAMPLE

When Life Freezes You

Includes the Three-Breath Pause practice & a morning reflection worksheet

by KETUL SHAH

[theunshakenself](#) — read the full book at launch

When Life Freezes You

Confusion is not your enemy — it is your invitation to grow

Imagine standing at a crossroads where every signpost has been washed blank by rain. You do not know which way leads home, which way leads forward, and which way leads to a dead end. Your feet feel heavy. Your mind races in circles. You want someone — anyone — to tell you what to do. This is utter confusion.

We are taught from childhood that confusion is a sign of weakness. If you do not know the answer, you are unprepared. If you hesitate, you are a coward. If you freeze, you are failing. But that is not true at all. The Bhagavad Gita opens with something radical — it opens with a hero who is completely, openly, unashamedly confused.

Arjuna, one of the greatest warriors the world had ever seen, does not stride into battle with a war cry. He asks his charioteer to stop. He looks at the armies on both sides and says, in essence, 'I cannot do this. I do not know what is right anymore.' This is not a moment of weakness. It is the most important moment of the entire Gita.

ARJUNA VISHADA YOGA

None of the wisdom, none of the life-changing teachings of the Gita would have happened if Arjuna had not first admitted that he was lost. His confusion was the door through which the light entered.

Think about your own life. When did you grow the most? Was it during the times when everything was smooth and comfortable? Or was it during the times when you did not know what to do next — when a relationship ended, a job disappeared, or a plan crumbled? If you are honest, you will notice that your deepest growth always came after your deepest confusion.

Confusion is not the opposite of clarity. It is the beginning of clarity. It is the soil cracking open before the seed can push through. When you feel confused, it means your old way of seeing the world is no longer big enough to hold the life you are living. Something inside you is outgrowing its container. That discomfort you feel is not a sign that something is wrong. It is a sign that something is ready to change.

The Anatomy of a Frozen Moment

Recognising your personal battlefields: kitchen, office, and mirror

There is a particular kind of moment that almost every human being knows. It is the moment when you need to act — you know you need to act — but your body will not move, your mouth will not open, and your thoughts spin so fast that they cancel each other out. You are frozen. Not lazy, not careless — frozen.

What is happening is not a failure. Modern science calls it freezing. When the stakes feel impossibly high, your nervous system shuts down. Your breath becomes shallow. Your thinking brain goes offline, and something older takes over. Arjuna's bow, Gandiva, slipped from his hands. His skin burned, his mouth went dry, his limbs trembled.

The battlefield of Kurukshetra is not somewhere far away. It is wherever you are standing right now. It might be the kitchen at seven in the morning packing lunches under stress, the office at three in the afternoon facing a demanding boss, or the mirror at midnight looking at your own reflection. These are our Kurukshetras. The real war is between the parts of yourself pulling in different directions — duty and desire, courage and fear.

THE THREE-BREATH PAUSE PRACTICE

The first chapter of the Gita gives us no solutions. It gives us something better: permission to be human. Arjuna sits down in his chariot and lets the full weight of what he is feeling wash over him. He does not run to a distraction. In our digital age, we run from discomfort into scrolls, screens, and apps. But sitting with discomfort is the foundation of mending.

To navigate these frozen moments, KETUL SHAH introduces the daily practice: The Three-Breath Pause.

- **First Breath (Body):** Inhale slowly, notice where the tension is (jaw, shoulders). As you exhale, let your shoulders drop half an inch. Notice, don't fix.
- **Second Breath (Mind):** Inhale, notice the story your mind is telling you ('This is unfair', 'I can't handle this'). As you exhale, let the story loosen its grip by one degree.
- **Third Breath (Choice):** Inhale, ask yourself: 'What does the wisest part of me want here?' Not what my anger or fear wants. Exhale and let your next action come from that quiet space.

MORNING REFLECTION WORKSHEET

Practicing the Three-Breath Pause

Use this page each morning for one week to build the habit before you need it in a real frozen moment. Keep answers short — a sentence or two is enough.

Date: _____

Day of practice: ____ / 7

1. Where did I feel frozen or stuck this week? (Kitchen, office, mirror — or somewhere else.)

2. First Breath — Body: Where was the tension held, and what happened when I let my shoulders drop?

3. Second Breath — Mind: What story was my mind telling me in that moment?

4. Third Breath — Choice: What did the wisest part of me actually want to do?

5. One small action I will take today that comes from that quieter, wiser place:

Enjoyed this sample? The full book contains 18 chapters of practices like this one, mapped to a complete framework for staying steady under pressure. Subscribe or pre-order at [theunshakenself](https://theunshakenself.com) to be notified the moment it's available.